Telarc Monster Cable flew three writers to Cincinnati as part of a promotional campaign for microphone cable. Telarc's recording setup is totally wired with Monster, from the microphones through the console (internally rewired with Monster interconnect) to the speakers. The weekend trip included a Saturday evening concert and a Sunday taping session. Since it was Halloween weekend, all the music was associated with death: Mussourgsky's Night on Bald Mountain, the cave scene from Grieg's Peer Gynt, the Saint-Saens funeral march that served as the theme of Alfred Hitchcock's TV show, etc. The bass drum was quite modest in size, smaller than the one the BSO uses, but its sound was as prominent in the hall as it is in Telarc recordings. The hall's sound is warm and bass-heavy, and the stage shell acts as a giant megaphone. Telarc's principal bass contribution seems to be precise placement and orientation of the bass drum at stage center to ensure that stage-area reflections rein- force rather than cancel its output. The drum was hit on its rear diaphragm, launching positive-pressure waves into the hall. (When a bass drum is struck on the front, much of the initial wavefront is a rarefaction.) Ambience-wise, the hall is a bit too dead with an au- dience but is virtually ideal for recording when empty. Music Hall has heavily upholstered seats with a soft, ab- sorbent exterior; consequently the acoustics, unlike Boston's Symphony Hall and Sanders Theater, don't be- come excessively live when the audience goes home. Jack Renner and conductor Erich Kunzel credit the hall's acoustics for the success of their recordings, and Telarc wants to install a permanent monitoring room in Cincinnati's Music Hall for use with recording projects other than the Pops. The orchestra was recorded with three omnidirec- tional mikes on tall stands at the lip of the stage (surprisingly close to the front of the orchestra), plus two ambience mikes on very tall stands in the cross-aisle, halfway back in the hall. For pops repertoire the main mikes are mounted relatively low and close, eight or nine feet above the stage floor and just behind the con- ductor, to enhance detail. For all-classical repertoire they are moved a foot higher and a few inches farther away, to achieve a more blended sound. Spot mikes may be added to bring out certain instruments in some movie/TV music. For recent recordings with chorus (e.g. The Sound of Music), the chorus was placed in audience seats, just behind the main mikes, so no accent mikes were needed for the chorus. Renner agrees that some of his European recordings, especially in England, are too reverberant and diffuse; the halls had so much reverb that they couldn't be tamed. (Those halls work better with the cardioid and figure-eight mikes that British en- gineers favor). The monitoring room was a converted ladies' lounge, about twice the size of a typical living room (and with double the ceiling height). ADS 1530 speakers were lo- cated a foot or two from the front wall, with ASC Tube Traps standing in the front corners. Absorptive panels were mounted between the speakers and on the side walls to kill reflections. A six-foot tall array of RPG dif- fusors spanned the width of the room behind the engi- neers, a few feet in front of the back wall. The digital processors and whirring VTRs were installed behind the wall of diffusers. They included a Soundstream, a Sony PCM-1630 with UMatic VCR, a PCM-F1 with Beta, and an experimental machine. The F1 tape has actually been used in several recordings when both the main and backup tapes failed. (And after successfully using the Colossus digital recorder twice, Telarc tried it several more times but found its sonic performance erratic.) Engineer Jack Renner is responsible for the entire set- up; then he just monitors during recording, while pro- ducer Bob Woods and conductor Kunzel make all deci- sions on retakes. Renner and editor Elaine Martone monitored via speakers to judge overall balance and pacing, while Woods monitored via Sony headphones to detect tiny performance flaws. For most of the recording just five mike inputs were used, and the rear ambience were mixed in at a very low level. The only change dur- ing the music was an occasional slight tweaking of the left-channel level and high-frequency EQ (to keep vio- lins from being drowned out during heavy brass pas- sages). How good was the sound? Like a very good hi-fi system; it did not have the magically "real" feeling that is sometimes obtained with a state-of-the-art audiophile system. Traditionally it has been assumed that recording engineers hear their recordings better than consumers do, but the opposite is more and more the case. Most of the Pops selections, such as TV scores and relatively brief classical items, were recorded in one or two takes apiece. Complex classical material like Mus- sorgsky's Night on Bald Mountain took about 40 takes, many in the difficult section near the end where instru- ments enter in pairs and Woods wanted exact intonation and ensemble timing for each entry. Lots of work will be done on a digital editor by Elaine Martone to put this recording into final shape. — Peter Mitchell (California) December 1988 BAS Meeting David Moran called the meeting to order at the Trans- portation Systems Center in Cambridge with a welcome to several newcomers. The presentation planned for the evening: a new subwoofer design by Poh Ser Hsu (with a pair of dbx 2500s used as satellites). dbx is not completely going out of business, by the way; the consumer, speaker, and pro lines will continue. The OEM component business has been sold (since this meeting) to THAT Corporation (named for the princi- pals, who are Les Tyler, Gary Hebert, and Paul Trava- line), and the sale of pro to AKG (less the RTA-1!) is inching toward completion. 